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## Focus Group Discussions: An Approach of Qualitative Research

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**Introduction :** The use of focus groups in social research increased considerably over the last two decades of the twentieth century. We use the phrase 'group discussions' as being synonymous with focus groups - the aim of a focus group or group discussions being to encourage the group to interact with each other. Although the term 'focus group' was once perhaps particularly associated with market research and 'group discussion' with social research, this distinction is now less clear. Focus groups originated among social scientists working in applied and academic research setting.

Berg and Lune (2012) trace the first use of focus groups back to the beginning of the second world war, where Paul Lazarsfeld and Robert K. Merton used them to explore the effectiveness of radio programs designed to boost army morale. But they are now well established as a mainstream method of qualitative social research, and seen as an extremely valuable data collection method.

### Key Features of Focus Group

A collective context of focus groups creates a process which is in important respects very different from an in-depth interview, primarily because data are generated by interaction between group participants. Participant present their own views and experience, but they also hear from other people. They listen, reflect on what is said, and in the light of this consider their own standpoint further. Additional is thus triggered in response to what they hear from others. Participants ask questions of each other, seek clarification, comment on what they have heard and prompt others to reveal more. As the discussion progresses (backwards and forwards, round and round the group). Individual response becomes sharpened and refined, and moves to a deeper and more considered level.

A focus group is therefore not a collection of individual interviews with comments directly solely through the researcher. This is better described as a 'Group Interview', and lacks both the depth of individual interviews and the richness that comes with using the group process. Instead, focus groups are synergistic in that the group interaction is explicitly used to generate data and insights.

A further feature of focus groups is the spontaneity that arises from the social context. In responding to each other, participants reveal more of their own frame of reference on the subject of study.

"Focus Groups....require the participants to give certain types of contribution, and they require the interaction to be organized in certain ways. In this sense, they are situations of formal interaction. Yet....moderators attempt to generate a situation where interaction seems fluid and spontaneous."

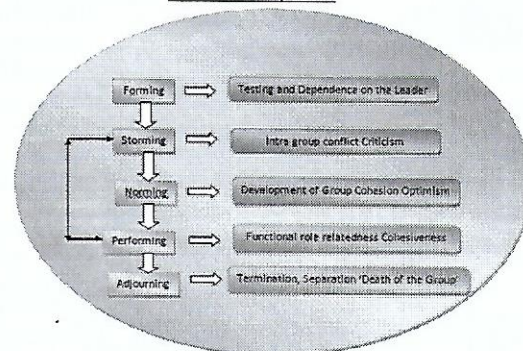
(Puchta and Potter, 2004)

**Group Processes and the Stages of a Focus Group :** An understanding of group processes and models of small group behavior is helpful to offer insight into what can happen in focus groups, and why. Group process have implications for the appropriate strategies to be facilitate the group as it moves through different phases.

Based on an examination of studies of small groups, Tuckman (1965) in collaboration with Jenson identified five sequential stages that groups tend to pass through. The model was based on examination of studies of small groups which were mainly therapy and training groups, but it also resonates with the processes observed in focus groups for research, particularly where participant do not already know each other, and has proved valuable in informing moderation techniques.

### A Model of Group Phases

A Model of Group Phases



**Stages of Focus Group :** The stages of focus group that moderating a group discussion involves and the tasks for the researcher within each, reflecting the group development phases described. The different stages explored here -

**1. Scene-Setting and Ground Rules :** The introductory stages of a focus group are very important and should be used to both inform participants about what will be expected of them and also set out the way in which the group will be conducted.

**2. Individual Introductions :** This helps the researcher to identify each participant but also ensures each has an opportunity to speak from the outset and identity with each other.

**3. The Opening Topic :** A general, neutral opener (that relates to the research topic) can help build up the group's discussion and dynamic.

**4. Discussion :** This is the main body of the focus group, with the key issues discussed and explored by the group and space given for them to move the discussion into new areas or formulate their views.

**5. Ending the Discussion :** It is helpful to signal in advance that the discussion is coming to an end and gradually relax the focus with some general final points and

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questions before the researcher clearly ends the group, letting participants know what will happen next and thanking them for their construction.

### Conducting the Discussion (Researcher's Role)

- 1- Keeping the discussion relevant and focused
- 2- Choosing when to allow more free-ranging discussion with minimal intervention
- 3- Knowing when to use silence as a means of promoting further reflection and debate

**Online Focus Groups :** Online focus groups have become viable and valuable means to conduct research. It is very helpful for the researchers especially when they have to collect the data in the form of perceptions & attitudes of the group. It can be used in place of traditional methods of qualitative studies.

The main advantage of online focus group is that the respondents can be taken from the diverse geographical locations as well as from the different demographic and social groups. It is also cost effective and less time

consuming. It saves travelling time & cost of the researcher and the research can be conducted in a short period of time. Besides these there are many more benefits of online focus group method like it provides openness to respondents, facilitates scheduling of the participants interaction in certain period etc.

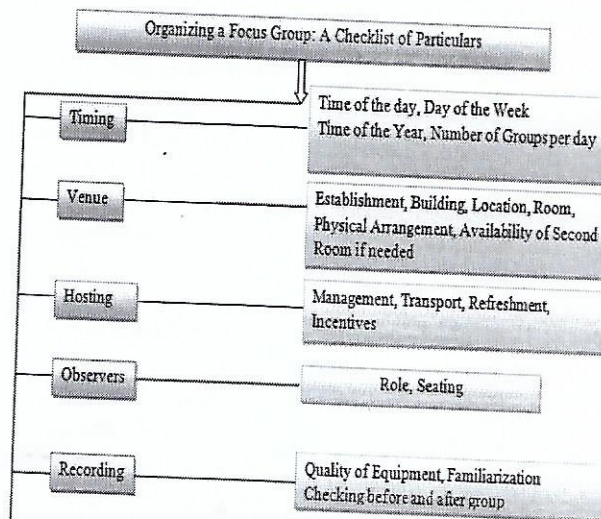
**There are two types of online focus groups:**

**1. Chat Room Focus Groups :** It involves participants signing into a designated site at the same time and exchanging views using online chat software.

**2. Bulletin Board Focus Groups :** It involves individuals participating in an asynchronous online discussion over the course of several days. For example if we have to use this method for research then it can be conducted in the following steps-

- Day 1 - Discuss the Problem
- Day 2 - Narrow down the Discussion of the Problem
- Day 3 - Discuss Possible Solution
- Day 4 - Identify the Preferred Solution
- Day 5 - Implement the Solution/Moving ahead, etc

The above mentioned steps are the probable steps of finding solution to a research problem by using Bulletin Board Focus Group.



**Conclusion :** In social and educational researches where people's behavior, emotions, attitude and ideas are important constituent of relevant data can be gathered or produced through the process of focus group discussion. The systematic and structured form to organize focus group discussion through vary in situations according to nature of problem, group of participant and type of data to be required for effective and valid solution or interpretation of issue under investigation. In various educational situations related with classroom, management, multilingual and multicultural classroom, diverse classroom, social cooperation to school focus group discussion in most powerful tool for qualitative data collection. The use of this technique is now increasing day by day and becoming popular among researcher's of behavioral sciences favoring qualitative research paradigm. It accepts the diversity of opinion and simultaneously creates a ground for common consensus for a issue and thus tolerance and dignity of mutual

respect in process of construction of knowledge in incorporated by the method. It makes it free from inhumane way as adopted by quantitative so called objective methods and involves real voices of life full of experiences and enrich the understanding of researcher about phenomena.

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